

TEST SCORES			
	Stock Speed (3325MHz)	Overclocked (4123MHz)	Overclocked (4412MHz)
3DMark Vantage			
Overall Score	34674	39494	41399
GPU Score	36138	40099	41828
CPU Score	30916	37785	40161
HAWX			
1920x1200 / DX10 / 4x FSAA / Max Detail	148	154	165
1920x1200 / DX10 / 8x FSAA / Max Detail	139	146	151
Far Cry 2			
1920x1200 / DX10 / Ultra High	146.21	162.56	181.95
1920x1200 / DX10 / Ultra High – 4x AA	143.51	160.22	178.26
1920x1200 / DX10 / Ultra High – 8x AA	143.75	156.79	167.56
Cinebench 10			
OpenGL	8711	9934	10158
Multiple CPU Render Test	21546	26861	28249

of Kingston DDR3 HyperX RAM. Our faithful WD Velociraptor would be the drive of choice for this supreme system. One Velociraptor would suffice, but we thought we'd push the envelope. We went with a RAID 0 configuration with two WD Velociraptors.

The grand gaming performance would have to come from a really powerful graphics card. Once again, the fastest card had to be procured. XFX's Radeon 5970 was the card. But wait, one card wouldn't be enough, so we got two of them. XFX sent us their Black Edition Radeon 5970s cards. To power this mammoth of a system, we needed a reliable power supply and of course, a chassis. Cooler Master's Silent Pro 1200W Gold rated power supply was used to power the two power hungry Radeon 5970s. The Cooler Master HAF X chassis would have ample space, plenty of fans and it would be sturdy for our needs.

Corsair sent us their H50 liquid cooling unit. Keep in mind that we were looking to build a stable, everyday use system. The H50 might not



A few Velociraptor drives for the RAID

be the ultimate water cooling kit in the world, but it sure is compact, easy to setup and it does the job rather well. Monitoring the Intel Core i7 980X idle at 33C gave us a good feeling.

We weren't going to be using a silly 17-inch CRT for this system, so we called in for a Viewsonic VP2655WB, a 26-inch IPS panel LCD from the Pro series of displays. Just the sight of the desktop made most of us hate the TN panel LCDs we're so used to seeing. The Razer

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Lachesis was brought in for the gaming that might occur post-overclocking.

Let's start assembling

We put together the entire rig one piece at the time. We started by mounting the processor on the board and applying a thin layer of thermal paste on it. The mounting for the H50 cooler hooked on to the board easily and then went the main block. We then connected the radiator unit to the back of the cabinet.

The memory went in next, followed by the two Radeon 5970 graphics cards. The installation was a close fit with the two cards hugging each other. The Velociraptor drives and the power supply followed. Quite honestly, the cable setup was not the ideal setup. We're talking of two auxiliary power connections, four power connections for the power supplies. Two more for the hard drives, one for the optical drive, and a large 24-pin power connector for the mainboard.

We booted up with fingers crossed to see if it would be one of those starts without hiccups. It proved to be so. The idle temperature of the processor didn't cross 33 to 35C, which was a good sign. A quick run to 4 GHz was successful in a matter of seconds. Remember that the stock speed for the Core i7 980X is 3.33 GHz (133 x 25). We left the settings to the defaults, and went ahead with the Windows installation.

The tests and benchmarks

Testing of the system was no different from other products. We installed the latest drivers for the graphics card and the motherboard along with the RAID controller. The drives were setup in RAID 0 configuration for the best performance. The plan was to note down a few scores and then overclock the other components.

A couple of benchmarks were installed and we were on our way. The initial scores we received were all very promising. The scores of the initial and final runs are given in the table.

Let the overclocking commence!

The setting up of the rig went on